This raising of the masses was to be achieved through their education and their liberation. India had to be liberated, not just from British rule but from itself:

> The present Hindu society is organised only for spiritual men, and hopelessly crushes everybody else … Our ancestors freed religious thought, and we have a wonderful religion. But they put a heavy chain on the feet of society, and our society is, in a word, horrid, diabolical. Liberty is the first condition of growth. Just as man must have liberty to think and speak, so must he have liberty in food, dress and marriage and in every other thing, so long as he does not injure others … No priestcraft, no social tyranny! … None deserves tyranny who is not ready to give liberty.[11]

Ten months after his visit to Kanyakumari Swami Vivekananda was speaking for India at the Parliament of the World's Religions in Chicago, an ambitious three-week event staged to bring together all the world's faiths. Although never officially credited as a delegate, Vivekananda dominated the proceedings with his forceful personality, his fluency in English and his sheer charisma. Over the course of five lectures at the parliament and subsequently in his lecture tours in the United States and Europe he presented an image of Hindu India that had far-reaching consequences, initiating a process of rebranding by which the West's view of a land mired in superstition was replaced by a perception of India as a country of unique spirituality based on ancient truths.

This rebranding included the deliberate softening of some of the cruder edges of Hinduism as perceived by its critics in the West. For example, at the Paris Congress of the History of Religions in 1900, Swami Vivekananda denounced as ridiculous the views of the previous speaker, the distinguished German Sanskritist Dr Gustav Oppert, who